

THE CALL Sir Syed mosque inside the AMU campus

the proposal. "They are only focused on the politics of name change, not on improving the town's condition," cribs Hussain. He also dismissed the Swami Haridas connection, claiming the *sant* was born near Vrindavan, 65 km from Aligarh.

The renaming fever is infectious: there's a surge in demand for a similar 'makeover' from other cities. Recently, in Agra, a lawmaker proposed moving the Taj to Agravan or Agarwal; another mooted reinventing Muzaffarnagar as Laxmi Nagar and Mainpuri as Mayan Nagar (a sage named Mayan has been discovered). Of course, none of this harms the ruling party. Says a senior BJP leader, "Religious and local sentiments can't be ignored. The name change of Allahabad and Faizabad helped us build a narrative of commitment—of course, it helps us politically too. I am sure the name change of Aligarh will help us in the Braj region in 2024." In India, history is a sub-discipline of political science. ■

WEST BENGAL

WHAT'S IN A RENAME?

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

On October 17, while inaugurating a Durga Puja in Kolkata, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee decided that a slum should no more be called a *basti*—the Bangla word used for a slum, which has gathered all the usual socio-economic connotations reserved for words marking out the poor. She instructed Kolkata mayor and minister Firhad Hakim to change their generic name to the rather more exalted *uttaran*—'ascension' in Bangla. The government even came up with advertisements publicising the step. But many slum-dwellers across Bengal's urban areas and especially in Kolkata soon discovered a dire facet to this exaltation—literally, a sense of being lifted off the ground under their feet.

This relates to the fact that the land on which many have resided for generations has of late been claimed by builders, and residents are being served eviction notices. For quinquagenarian Tarun Raychowdhury, the fight to save his residence in a slum on the eastern fringes of Kolkata began eight years back. He's among the 133 residents of 4, Ram Mohan Mullick Garden Lane who were asked to vacate their homes in April 2015 by a real estate firm, which claimed that it owned 6.3 acres of the land on which the *basti* stood. An even bigger shock awaited them after the eviction notices. Raychowdhury explains, "We have been paying for this property as *thika* tenants for years. But when we went to pay our municipal taxes, there was no record identifying us as the legal lessees."

Several big slums in Kolkata are situated on *thika* tenancy lands, where registered residents are recognised as lessees of the state government/ individual owners and can build houses on small parcels of land. The rights of such *thika* tenants in Kolkata and other urban areas, who are liable to pay rent, are guided by the West Bengal Thika Tenancy (Acquisition and Regulation) Act. Most slums—which cumulatively cover around one-third of the area under the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC)—are made up of *thika* tenants. However, many slums are not recognised by the state, since dwellers there are not legally registered.

Raychowdhury says they found all documents at the KMC identified the real estate developer as the owner of the land on which their slum is located. The families were left with no option but to move court, thus being drawn into a long legal battle. CPI(M) MP and

SLUM UPLIFT

- **Mamata Banerjee has renamed *basti*–slum in Bangla–to *uttaran*, meaning 'ascension'**
- **The WB Slum Development Federation calls this an 'eyewash', says the government has changed laws so that developers can evict slum-dwellers**
- **The TMC denies the charges, lists development work in slums**